

## **Walking on All-Hallows, 1971**

By Rosanne Wasserman,

Blue letters: E –  
Z – R – A on the concrete  
walkway  
threading a flat grass meadow.  
A voodoo? Will someone vanish, the way  
the blue paintstrokes will fade to a ghost,  
too faint to read,  
underfoot?

Activity,  
sparrow and squirrel!—morning  
running  
to ready the winter beds;  
leaves cling in perilous places, cleaving  
to birds' perches, one ghostly moment—  
Are you a tree  
now, Roethke,

letting green words  
leaf out, turn gold, be scattered  
by birds?  
Poems, said in leaffalls, bloodred,  
and, save for squirrel and field mouse, unheard?  
Blue paint haunts the walk a moment: EZRA  
POUND IS EIGHTY-  
SIX, it says.

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## **The Mind Is an Enchaining Thing**

Rosanne Wasserman,  
*with apologies to Marianne Moore*

Is an enchained thing  
    like the glaze on a  
waterbird's wing  
        gummed with petroleum  
        web and rachides frozen.  
Like foghorns played rpf 16,

like the (asterisk) “all”  
as a crutch, or the  
smog-cloud’s rainfall  
of dark weather, the mind  
blocking its way as though blind,  
trips over its own feet on the ground.

It has memory’s ear  
that repeats, without  
seeming to, here.  
Like the half-expected Fall,  
truly unequivocal,  
proving its pregnant uncertainty,

it is its own power’s  
self-destruction. It  
could watch hours  
of pigeons’ mating sea-  
sons. It is memory’s “me,”  
conscious, a constant consistency.

It veils all tears, fearing  
temptations; tears mask  
its heart, weary  
tears its eyes. If the heart  
tries faces, it makes, in part,  
rejections, in favor of pigeon-

dull incessance, a bored  
constancy, worse than  
Stockhausen’s chord—  
Profusions, profusions permit  
its refusal to choose: it  
knows it’s no king christ who cannot err.

Previously unpublished.